

CFO-RC FILE #

RESULTS: 7-0 A
*Red 4/26/00 wpl***COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM**

(PLEASE PRINT OR TYPE. ATTACH PHOTOGRAPHS, DRAWINGS AND ADDITIONAL PAGES AS NECESSARY)

SPECIES: TUFTED DUCK Aythya fuligula
(Common Name) (Scientific Name)DATE(S) OF OBSERVATION: March 28, 2000NUMBER OF BIRDS SEEN: 1 SEX: male PLUMAGE: Definitive alternateEXACT LOCATION: southeast side of Barr Lake (State Park), appx. 1 mile south of Vis. CenCOUNTY: Adams NEAREST TOWN: Barr ELEVATION: 5000'LENGTH OF OBSERVATION: 30 min. TIME(S) OF OBSERVATION: 1010 -1020 and 1245-OTHER OBSERVERS WHO SAW THE BIRD(S) WITH YOU: none 1305 MST
(first time from the first blind so. of the Vis. Cen.; p.m.-from a second blind farther south)OTHER OBSERVERS WHO INDEPENDENTLY SAW THE BIRD(S): none that I know of.LIGHT CONDITIONS (QUALITY; DIRECTION RELATIVE TO BIRD(S); POSITION): general overcast, no glare or backlighting. Waterfowl to the west and northwest.OPTICAL EQUIPMENT USED: Swarovski 8 x 56 binoc, Kowa TSN 4 scope, 20-60 zoomDISTANCE FROM BIRD (ESTIMATED UNLESS OTHERWISE NOTED): closest - 100 yds. to as far as 300 yds.WAS BIRD PHOTOGRAPHED? no IF SO, HAVE YOU SUBMITTED PHOTOS? _____

WHO TOOK THE PHOTOGRAPHS? _____

DESCRIBE THE GENERAL AND SPECIFIC HABITAT IN WHICH THE BIRD(S) OCCURRED:

Large plains reservoir, water used for agricultural irrigation, water level high; wooded and shrubby/willow shoreline, 10 miles circumference approximately. Shows extensive sandbars extending into the reservoir when water level is low. South end set aside as refuge, apart from fishing area at the north end.

DESCRIBE THE BIRD'S BEHAVIOR (FLYING; FEEDING; HABITS; BEHAVIORS USED IN IDENTIFYING THE SPECIES OR IN SUPPORTING THE IDENTIFICATION):

SEE ATTACHED.

BEHAVIOR: In a.m., resting and slowly swimming on the water among 100's of Greater Scaup, most of which were sleeping. Awake and alert, wary, but occasionally preening, dipping head in water and shaking head, flailing the "ponytail" tuft on its head. Flushed spontaneously with a dozen Greater Scaup near it and flew to west and disappeared.

P.M. - discovered sleeping at edge of large raft of Greater Scaup, bill tucked in back feathers. Roused 3 x and looked around, appeared to take a drink and returned to sleep. I then left to report sighting to CBO office.

DESCRIPTION: I was at Barr Lake to study the "1000 Greater Scaup" reported on the RBA tape. Scanning the lake from the north revealed only a few scattered waterfowl. I was sure the scaup had left. I decided to walk around the east side of the lake to the gazebo, with scope in tow, and check the waterfowl along the way.

At 0945, I stopped at the first observation blind and scoped the Am. Coots, Gadwalls, No. Shovelers and Buffleheads close to shore. I was getting ready to leave when a huge flock of ducks flew in from ?? and settled 150-300 Yds. off-shore from the blind. I slowly moved outside to the front of the blind, made myself comfortable on my folding stool and proceeded to scan through the ducks. I estimated 700 Greater Scaup, both male and female in the group within scope range with up to 2000 more scaup species resting on the water farther out. A few other waterfowl species, Common Goldeneye, (200) Ruddy Duck, Redhead and a single male Red-breasted Merganser were viewable. (Later, a male and female Barrow's Goldeneye joined the group.)

Into my scope view swam an unmistakable Tufted Duck (TUDU), 125 yds. out, at 1010 MST. The whole raft of ducks seemed to be floating closer to shore. The TUDU was an adult male in all his glory, moving from left to right, through the mass of Greater Scaup, his right profile clearly visible. His long, black "ponytail" dangled from the rear of the crown, down the back of the head but separated from the nape so that it was silhouetted against the water in the background. It did not touch the back. This duck appeared to be the same size and general body build as the Greater Scaup. He stood out during the observation period, not only by the long "tuft", but also because of the solid black uppers, unlike the "gray" color of the scaup uppers. Specifically, when resting on the water, the back, scapulars, tertials, tail/uppertail coverts and outer primaries were entirely black, as were the symmetrically rounded head, tuft, neck and breast.

The pale iris of the eye was striking against the black face. The bill was scaup size, shape and color - a typical medium-large sized bill, blue-gray with a prominent black tip. A very narrow, whitish/pale blue band bordered the back edge of the black tip, across the width of the bill. Neither the pale border nor black tip were as extensive as on Ring-necked Duck, but the tip was more extensively black than that seen on the Greater Scaup.

The sides, flanks and belly (in flight) were pure white, bordered by black near the tail/ventral area. Because of the overcast, no sheen color was noted on the head.

Most of the observation time was of lateral views and always of direct, close comparisons with the Greater Scaup, but when the Tufted Duck flushed at 1020 MST, I could see the long bright white wing stripe on the upper wings, running through all the secondaries out at least halfway through the primaries and nearly to the outer most primaries, which were black. This wide trailing edge provided the only contrast to the black upperparts. Wing lining was not clearly observed, but appeared mostly pale.

The legs were not seen, so unable to check for band. It was most likely a wild bird considering the enormous numbers of scaup present, a species with which Tufted Duck associates in the wild.

The TUDU was again seen in the early afternoon, sleeping at the edge of the scaup raft, 100 yds. out, its tuft disheveled in the breeze, like a shaggy punk hairstyle on a rocker, standing out from all the sleek-headed scaup. I left it, still sleeping, (the duck, not me!).

ELIMINATION OF SIMILAR SPECIES: Lesser Scaup are somewhat smaller in overall size; gray back, scapulars and upperwing coverts, rather than black of TUDU. Head shape is

(continued:)

TUFTED DUCK continued: 3/28/2000

different: peaked near hind crown, not rounded, ^{or at times, flat crowned} as in TUDU. White upperwing stripe on secondaries only. Finally, this species lacks a head tuft and the black on bill tip is confined to the nail.

Greater Scaup - as above except slightly larger and head shape; primary and secondary stripe same as TUDU. Black on bill tip often spreads slightly out from the nail, but over smaller area than TUDU.

Ring-necked Duck - Has black head, neck and uppers, but has gray sides and flanks with obvious white verticle bar separating black breast from gray sides. Head shape more like Lesser Scaup; broad white bill band and narrow white border around base of bill are distinctive. Lacks tuft. In flight, upperwing shows gray secondaries, not white.

During all observations, ^{TUDU} tail position was different from scaup: seen resting at water level, while scaup tails had a perky little angle upwards, perhaps at 30 degrees or greater. I found this rather intriguing.

BIRD'S CALL: none

PRIOR EXPERIENCE: Have seen thousands of Lesser Scaup and Ring-necked Ducks and a few Greater Scaup annually in Colo. and more in Alaska.

Saw a male Def. Alt. Tufted Duck in Boulder, Colo., 3/21/1997.

BOOKS: None were available during observation. Reviewed National Geo. and Waterfowl by Madge and Burn later at home for background information on this species.

REPORT MADE X DURING OBSERVATION.

DATE WRITTEN: 3/29/2000

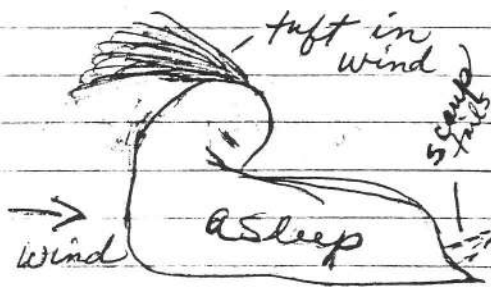
REPORTING OBSERVER Karleen Schofield
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Denver, Co. 80219
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SIGNATURE Karleen Schofield

3/28 cont

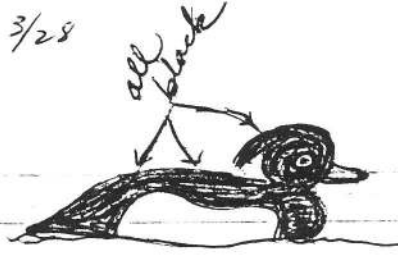
2nd Sighting - 2nd blind
12:45 - 1:05

Awoke 3x briefly,
then bk to sleep



tail usually held
close to water,
not angled up
as in Gt. Scaup.

3/28



second +
primaries nearly full
length of wings in
flight away from
me + to the right.
Seemed wary/alert
most of time - occas.
preening, dipping
head in water +